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English 7 Purple

9 December 2024

The Characterization of Hermes

The twelve great Olympians are commonly thought to be beautiful, powerful, and perfect. However, this isn't always the case. Hermes, the Greek god of merchants, thieves, and travelers, is far from perfect. Like everyday people, he faces challenges, makes mistakes, and learns things about the world as he embarks on various adventures. Based on *D'Aulaires' Book of Greek Myths* and Stephanie Spinner's novel *Quicksilver*, Hermes is characterized as clever, humorous, and caring.

Firstly, Hermes is characterized as clever. According to the novel, Hermes began playing tricks since he was a newborn on Mount Cyllene. The following describes the tricks newborn Hermes played on his brother Apollo. One example of this is when Hermes sets out to steal Apollo's cows. The book of Greek myths states, "To keep Apollo from knowing who had stolen his herd and which way they had been driven, Hermes slyly wrapped the hoofs of the cows with bark to disguise their prints, and tied brooms to their tails so they would erase their own tracks. To confuse Apollo even further, he drove the cows backward out of the pasture, and tied bundles of branches to his own little feet so it looked as if a giant had led something into the pasture, but nothing out" (D'Aulaires, 49). This shows that Hermes was clever, even as a little child. With only being a few hours old, he was able to trick his much more mature brother, Apollo. All of his

actions are outstanding compared to an average newborn his age. Most impressively, Hermes had a well-thought out plan and backup plan. Additionally, Hermes showed that he is clever later in life. Hades, god of the underworld, had stolen Kore, Demeter's daughter, and was forcing her to become his wife. When the gods found out, Demeter, the goddess of harvest, gets angry and threatens to stop all growth on Earth until Kore returns to her. To solve the problem, Hermes responds, "Say that Kore has to stay with Hades half the year because she ate the pomegranate seeds but that she can spend the rest of the year with Demeter" (Spinner, 45). This is an example of Hermes using his cleverness positively in a tough circumstance. As the messenger god, Hermes is truly persuasive, diplomatic, and sharp when it comes to making deals and agreements. Hermes was the only one capable of coming up with a compromise that worked for both sides. These are just some examples where Hermes uses his cleverness to his advantage in tricky situations.

Hermes is also a humorous character. Apollo, the god of sun and light, was enraged that his baby brother stole his best cows. According to the Greek myth, "All the gods burst out laughing when they saw innocent-looking little Hermes running with furious Apollo at his heels" (D'Aulaires, 53). Right as he was born, Hermes established his silly reputation. Hermes was capable of humoring all the gods, including Zeus, who is usually quite stolid. From then on, Hermes tries to use his humor as a way to gain his father's attention and appreciation. Years later, Hermes arrives in Hell for his mission to steal Kore back from Hades. This is because Hades had kidnapped Demeter's daughter, Kore, to be his wife. Hermes described his popularity among the dead souls. "They're overjoyed to see me when I visit because I tell them jokes. And I have to admit they're my best audience. They like puns. They like riddles. They even like mortal jokes" (Spinner, 18). Hell is known to be one of the darkest, most boring places in the world. By

bringing laughter to the dead, Hermes shows that his funny personality can light up even the darkest places. This allows many to take a liking for him, and this helps him create strong relationships with others. In conclusion, Hermes uses his humorous personality to make many positive relationships.

Finally, caring is another one of Hermes' traits. As mentioned before, Hermes stole 50 of Apollo's best cows as a newborn. After playing his tricks on Apollo, Hermes reflects on his actions to his wary mother. Hermes said to his mother Maia, "I did what I had to do for you and me. We don't want to live in this dark cave forever. Soon I will be seated on high Olympus as one of the twelve great gods, and you too will live there in glory as my mother" (D'Aulaires, 51). This shows that Hermes not only wants good and honor for himself, but for his mother as well. Maia had to endure lots of hardships in order to give birth to him, as she would have been targeted by Zeus's wife, Hera. They live in a dark cave on Mount Cyllene where no one knows about Hermes. Hermes is caring by being loyal to his mother, and being thankful for all that she has done for him. Another example of this is after Hermes successfully aids Perseus, Zeus's mortal child, with slaying the gorgon Medusa. Hermes retells, "As I stared at her lifeless body, my revulsion became sorrow—heavy, dark, guilt-laden. I hadn't killed Medusa, but I had made her death possible. *This is hateful*, I thought. *I'll never do it again*. With the vow my spirits lifted" (Spinner, 74). This is interesting, since Hermes should be proud that he had accomplished his task— to help Perseus slay Medusa. However, he still feels empathy for Medusa, as he still sees her as the young girl who had been cursed into a monster. By showing compassion for someone he is sworn to feel disgusted by, Hermes is showing that he cares for all living beings. Ultimately, these two examples prove that Hermes cares deeply for those closest to him, and he also cares for those who he doesn't know well.

In both *D'Aulaires' Book of Greek Myths* and *Quicksilver* by Stephanie Spinner, Hermes is portrayed as a clever, humorous, and caring character. These traits are evident as Hermes embarks on many journeys, develops relationships, and makes discoveries. Interestingly, all of these are aspects of human life. Just like everyday people, Hermes has a personality, overcomes challenges, and is not perfect.